

TOWARD A REDEFINITION OF URBAN FORM AND CULTURE

So it happens that, though Mr. Greeley so frequently and eagerly exhorts the young men of the country to go to the West, the young man observes that Mr. Greeley himself stays in the city of New York; and he follows the example of his adviser and does not take his advice.

— EDWARD EVERETT HALE

The location of the nation's capital in Washington, D.C., and the subsequent placement of most state capitals not in their largest cities but in geographical centers had profound implications for American urban culture. By artificially separating seats of government from the country's metropolitan areas, the revolutionary generation enshrined as cultural norms the agrarian ideal and an accompanying philosophical distrust of cities. Moreover, the growth of urban areas in the first half of the nineteenth century in some ways confirmed the worst fears of Jefferson and his contemporaries. The density of building in the walking city bred high rates of crime and disease. With the introduction of urban transportation systems, the gridiron spread inexorably over the surrounding countryside, thereby depriving city residents of contact with nature. Similarly, the rise of the industrial city threatened to bring the worst aspects of the British factory system to American shores, and the presence of the urban mobs Jefferson had warned against in 1785 seemed to portend the failure of America's republican experiment.¹

Given the conditions of life in the city during the antebellum era, it is not surprising that what historian Anselm Strauss has called a "dichotomy in American thought" between urban and rural values persisted as a central cultural fact during the nineteenth century. For succeeding generations the moral contrasts ascribed to country and city retained potent ideological implications. But this does not mean that nineteenth-century Americans were necessarily as anti-urban as they have sometimes been portrayed. In their influential book, *The Intellectual versus the City*, Morton and Lucia White trace what they

consider a "powerful tradition of anti-urbanism in the history of American thought"—one that extends from Thomas Jefferson and his contemporaries to the modern architect Frank Lloyd Wright, who died only three years before the book's publication in 1962. The Whites argue that there is "no persistent or pervasive tradition of romantic attachment to the city" in American literature or philosophy. The authors speculate that this repudiation of urban culture "by figures who represent major tendencies in American thought" continues to affect attitudes toward the city in our own time.²

To be sure, the tradition the Whites describe was a prominent aspect of American culture throughout the nineteenth century. Not only the "nation's most celebrated thinkers" cast doubt on the desirability of cities; so too did countless lesser writers, popular orators, ministers, and celebrants of woman's sphere. Nevertheless, the Whites overargue their case by positing country and city in a kind of Manichaeian dichotomy. As a result, their analysis leaves little room for an appreciation of the complex pattern of accommodation many Americans made to the realities of urban life, however distasteful or shocking they considered the city. Nor do the Whites account for the millions of people who, for various reasons, wrote with their feet rather than with pens by moving from farms or from abroad to the nation's cities. The dominant ideological strain may have been what historian Henry Nash Smith terms the "myth of the garden," a celebration of the superiority of agrarianism and the West over the urban East. But not everyone believed what they read in promotional tracts or dime novels. The image of the city frightened many nineteenth-century Americans, but it attracted and inspired many others.³

Indeed, careful analysis of the printed record and unpublished sources reveals the beginnings of a fundamental change in the way Americans perceived the city in the first half of the nineteenth century. Two developments help explain this change. One was a subtle restructuring of the agrarian ideology, a changing perception of nature that was an American expression of Romanticism. The other was the tenuous beginning of what Gunther Barth has identified as "modern city culture." Taken together, the refashioning of traditional agrarianism and the nascent appreciation of some aspects of city life led to a redefinition of urban form and culture and made possible the creation of the new urban landscape.⁴

In its clearest formulation—in the writings of such men as Jefferson and John Taylor of Caroline—the agrarian ideology was a program of social organization. Jefferson's affection for agriculture, for example, was predicated on the political belief that farmers possessed the independence that would guarantee the survival of the nation's republi-

can institutions. Many nineteenth-century Americans similarly judged a rural way of life to be most compatible with republican virtue. Andrew Jackson Downing, writing in the 1840s and early 1850s for enlightened inhabitants of agricultural districts as well as city dwellers with a taste for country pleasures, described farming as the "bone and sinew" of the nation. Pointing out that agriculture produced annually more than twice as much wealth as all other occupations combined, he called cultivators of the soil the "great industrial class" of the New World. Like Jefferson, Downing hoped that the United States would remain predominantly agrarian.⁵

A host of other writers echoed traditional claims for the primacy of agriculture, as publishers across the United States issued a dazzling array of books, magazines, almanacs, and pamphlets devoted to the subject. For example, a contribution to Downing's monthly, *The Horticulturist*, described farming as the most essential of all occupations and as the criterion of civilization everywhere on earth—as did the youthful Frederick Law Olmsted, who advised his brother to abandon academic study and instead take up farming. Rural pursuits, he reasoned, "tend to elevate and enlarge the ideas" and offer the able practitioner the opportunity to cultivate "taste and sentiment" as well as crops. Farming was a way of life, the most virtuous way of life, not simply a means of earning a living. And its rewards transcended economic values: the "charms of rural life," asserted a correspondent to the *Christian Examiner*, "are among the purest and most lasting pleasures which gladden the human heart."⁶

By the second quarter of the nineteenth century, however, the traditional defense of agrarianism was full of rhetorical flourishes that bore little resemblance to the practice of farming. The agrarian stability Jefferson envisioned had been replaced by what James Fenimore Cooper termed a "spirit of unrest," which characterized most rural communities in the two decades preceding the Civil War. From North and South, owners of small farms and large plantations moved inexorably westward, attracted by the lodestone of fertile land and economic opportunity. Tocqueville observed:

In the United States a man builds a house in which to spend his old age, and he sells it before the roof is on; he plants a garden and lets it just as the trees are coming into bearing; he brings a field into tillage and leaves other men to gather the crops; he embraces a profession and gives it up; he settles in a place, which he soon afterwards leaves to carry his changeable longings elsewhere.

Cooper, who after an extended absence in Europe returned during Jackson's presidency, was similarly distressed by American mobility and instability. His character Paul Powis lamented that a "disposition to change is getting to be universal in this country," a development he

considered "one of the worst signs of the times." In *Home as Found*, Cooper's "commodore" of Lake Otsego described Templeton's farmers as "unlucky fishermen, always ready to shift ground." Downing also recognized with dismay the "great tendency towards constant change, and the restless spirit of emigration, which form part of our national character."⁷

The transition from subsistence to commercial agriculture contributed to this "spirit of unrest." Although farmers living near cities had long sold their produce to urban customers, two new developments dramatically expanded the opportunities for marketing crops. One was the accelerated growth of cities, which increased the demand for produce; the other was the transportation revolution, which enlarged the geographical area able to provide foodstuffs to the urban population. The transportation revolution added new concerns of price fluctuation and competition from distant regions to such traditional risks as weather and crop productivity. This evolution in the rural way of life sounded the death knell of the agrarian ideal, for what may once have been a stable, industrious enterprise was becoming a speculative venture. Perhaps more important, the rise of commercial farming directly affected attitudes toward nature. Historian Robert Gross's studies of Concord, Massachusetts, in the mid-nineteenth century demonstrate that Transcendentalism was at least in part a response to the rise of a market economy.⁸

The agrarian ideology celebrated the "charms of rural life," forgetting that the farmer's lot was hardly one of refinement and ease. Unfortunately, few writers escaped the bounds of a literary convention that extolled a pastoral existence: most champions of a rural way of life failed to see—or at least to describe—the loneliness, monotony, and drudgery of the farm. Yet the instability abhorred by Cooper and Downing, and the pathos of Thoreau's John Field, were at least as real as the perfunctory recitations of rural virtue. Sidney George Fisher, an urbane Philadelphia diarist with a keen taste for country pleasures, lamented that a "man of any education cannot live among farmers in this country. The moment you leave the neighborhood of a city," he asserted, "you are in the midst of barbarism, except in a very few spots in America."⁹

Few spokesmen would have gone so far as Fisher in describing farming as a new form of barbarism, but increasingly, during the first half of the nineteenth century, traditional agrarianism dissolved into nostalgia and an appreciation for natural scenery. As the landscape became more and more domesticated, artists and writers celebrated not the rigors of agriculture—which, after all, necessarily required alteration of the environment—but the beauties of "Dame Nature." The pages of literary magazines filled with "reveries" in the Hudson Highlands, and members of the eastern cultural elite began flocking to

such popular resorts as Cozzens' Hotel and the Catskill Mountain House to partake of the scenery. Not only the elite enjoyed such pleasures. Hartford merchant John Olmsted took his son Frederick on "tours in search of the picturesque," and the son later recalled how deeply the perception of nature affected his father and shaped his own life:

On a Sunday evening we were crossing the meadows alone. I was tired and he had taken me in his arms. I soon noticed that he was inattentive to my prattle and looking into his face saw in it something unusual. Following the direction of his eyes, I said: "Oh! there's a star." Then he said something of Infinite Love with a tone and manner which really moved me, chick that I was, so much that it has ever since remained in my heart.

Nature, then, became a source of inspiration, a place not for hard work but for contemplation, for tranquility and renewal.¹⁰

Thus by mid-century a subtle reworking of the agrarian ideology was evident: critics had begun to fault the city not only in Jefferson's political and social terms but also because it was not "the country." Urban growth was especially regrettable because it deprived residents of daily contact with nature. Predictably, these new critics reasoned that the absence of nature in cities was the source of poor health, poor morals, and insanity. Tocqueville, for example, was told that "madness is commoner" in America than elsewhere, while Swedish novelist Fredrika Bremer found that the bustle of New York produced in its inhabitants "restless, deeply-sunk eyes" and "excited, wearied features." The American Medical Association's Committee on Public Hygiene similarly concluded that conditions in cities resulted in the "destruction of human life," and some years later Frederick Law Olmsted attributed to cities a harmful impact on the "nerves and minds" of their residents.¹¹

Many writers at mid-century invidiously compared the city with the country, a place they esteemed for its contributions to health and morality. The authors of *Village and Farm Cottages* enumerated advantages to health among the "peculiar and beneficial influences of rural life." Moreover, they claimed, in the country "moral influences are much better than those of the city, as the air is much more salubrious." A writer in the *Horticulturist* described a rural existence as especially desirable because it offered relief from the "din and turmoil of the city." In a series of designs for inexpensive cottages published in 1848, the architect Thomas Thomas, Jr., attempted to make it possible for laborers and their families to escape the tenements and the "unhealthy and immoral influences of city life."¹²

Keepers of the new agrarianism invariably portrayed rural life as the virtuous counterpoint to the city. Henry Ward Beecher, for exam-

ple, praised the farm for training men to industry, self-reliance, morality, and enterprise and claimed that cities were "only saved from physical degeneracy, by large annual draughts from the rural population." Lewis F. Allen, the prolific writer on agricultural subjects, asserted that

from the farm chiefly springs that energetic class of men, who replace the enervated and physically decaying multitude continually thrown off in the waste-weir of our great commercial and manufacturing cities and towns, whose population, without the infusion—and that continually—of the strong, substantial, and vigorous life blood of the country, would soon dwindle into insignificance and decrepitude.

Success in urban enterprise, however, was not enough. A writer in the *Atlantic Monthly* predicted that the nostalgic child of the farm would evoke "the vision of the old homestead, . . . a picture of rural life, so homey, yet so beautiful, that the heart will breathe a sigh upon it, and the voice will say, 'It were better so.'"¹³

But, of course, it would not be so. Folklore, literary convention, and Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis notwithstanding, relatively few nineteenth-century Americans moved from cities to farms. Instead, the children of agricultural districts migrated to cities and there joined the immigrants, who were swelling the population of urban areas. The rate of urban growth was alarming. In 1790 there were only twenty-two towns with populations greater than twenty-five hundred (the criterion then used by the census bureau to define an urban area), and only three cities exceeding twenty-five thousand. By 1830 three cities had surpassed fifty thousand, and New York housed more than one hundred thousand residents. Worse, the pace of growth was accelerating: Stuart Blumin and Allan Pred have pointed out that the years from 1820 to 1860 marked the greatest decennial rates of increase in the urban population in American history.¹⁴

Even more ominous was the rise of the industrial city. The first large-scale manufacturing establishments had been located on rural sites and had relied upon a transient female labor force. By the 1840s, however, these towns were becoming cities. Soon after its founding, the industrial complex at Lowell, Massachusetts, had been praised as a beacon of republican prosperity, yet within twenty years it had grown from a sleepy New England village into the fourteenth largest city in the United States. Unsurprisingly, in Lowell many of Jefferson's worst fears were realized: an increasing visibility of poverty, the emergence of a landless, propertyless working class, and the growth of slums and urban diseases.¹⁵

The sheer numbers of newcomers to the cities taxed the ability of

municipal governments and philanthropic organizations to meet the increased demand for services. Population growth so outstripped the construction of new residential units that many New Yorkers lived in boarding houses or in very undesirable conditions in the crowded older neighborhoods. The density of building, the invention of the tenement house, and the proliferation of saloons and brothels resulted in what historian Kenneth T. Jackson has called an "increase in urban nuisances" and a decline in the quality of life. The problems of the city were real, not rhetorical, and nothing better symbolized them than street congestion or the poverty and squalor of New York's most notorious slum, the Five Points area.¹⁶

Nevertheless, the flourishing of urban cultural institutions in the decades preceding the Civil War enhanced the attractiveness of cities. Boston's Athenaeum, the Free Gallery of the Art Union of Philadelphia, and New York's American Art-Union, Dusseldorf Gallery, and National Academy of Design displayed contemporary painting and sculpture. Moses Kimball's Boston Museum and P. T. Barnum's American Museum appealed to people more interested in exotic curiosities; they also helped socialize newcomers to an urban way of life. The performing arts were thriving: playwright William K. Northall wondered in 1851 "if there be a city in the world of the same size and population which can exhibit a theatrical prosperity equal to New York." Impresarios established opera houses and academies of music, and Jenny Lind and other European artists sang to packed audiences throughout the country. Libraries, lyceums, and fraternal organizations enriched the intellectual and social life of cities and towns. These cultural institutions—vehicles for the realization of what Downing termed "popular refinement"—achieved their greatest measure of success in urban areas.¹⁷

Although much of the popular literature continued to depict the horrors of the "evil city," during the 1840s and 1850s an increasing number of religious, literary, and artistic leaders realized that the growth of urban areas was not an unmitigated evil. The Reverend Edwin Hubbell Chapin addressed the competing claims of country and city in a series of sermons published in 1853 under the title *Moral Aspects of City Life*. In this he paid due fealty to the virtues of a rural existence and admitted that the city "encloses all forms of corruption," that its "splendor is overlapped by poverty and crime." Chapin nevertheless located in cities the "symbols of civilization—the measures of human progress." Among the benefits associated with urban areas he enumerated "the departments of culture—the schools and lyceums" and "achievements in the worlds of matter and mind." Throughout his sermons Chapin praised the city's complexity, its diverse, anthropomorphic manifestations, as the closest physical approximation of human nature. In short, he wrote, "the interest of the

city is as superior to that of the country, as humanity is to nature; as the soul is to the theatre in which it is enacted." There is a "moral significance" to urban life, Chapin concluded, because "that which is strongest and noblest in our nature is illustrated in the city."¹⁸

Other spokesmen joined Chapin in celebrating the cultural potential of urban areas. Philadelphia librarian and antiquarian John Jay Smith found cities to be "great storehouses of Art and Knowledge," while attorney Frederick W. Sawyer described cities as "leaders in almost every thing that has been done for the amelioration and improvement of the condition of man." A writer in *Putnam's Monthly* went so far as to equate the development of them with the "history of the civilized world." At a time when a majority of his contemporaries were appalled by urban growth, this writer intrepidly claimed that the "world's progress in civilization, in art, in knowledge of 'things human and divine,' [had] been mainly caused and promoted by and through the agency of great cities."¹⁹

Still, most Americans at mid-century found the prospect of an urban nation troubling. The increasing importance of the city as an economic and cultural institution, however, attracted even people with strong attachments to the farm. Historian R. Richard Wohl has demonstrated the duality of the "country boy" myth in nineteenth-century literature to be a portrayal of the city as a corrupting Babylon and, somewhat incongruously, an arena in which rural virtue gained entrepreneurial success. This tenuous juxtaposition, a lurid depiction of immorality in the city and the triumph of the old agrarian order over the new, suggests the degree to which urban imagery plagued the keepers of the Jeffersonian conscience. Dreaded though the perils of the city might be, not even the experience of "Arthur in Babylon," a tale of virtue corrupted, could stem the growth of the urban population.²⁰

The migration of millions of Arthurs from farms and from abroad in the 1840s and 1850s created obvious problems, many of them intractable, but it also created unprecedented economic and cultural opportunities. Even in its new formulation the agrarian ideology remained formidable, but the growth of urban cultural institutions had made the amenities of city life tempting indeed. Thus in the two decades preceding the Civil War the intellectual and cultural response to cities and their place in "Nature's Nation" became increasingly complex. Instead of an outright rejection of cities, as the Whites maintain, a pattern of ambivalence, characterized by grudging acceptance and accommodation, emerged in American thought.

Ralph Waldo Emerson personifies this new duality in attitudes toward country and city. Much of his published writing predicted that rural life would have a powerfully "sanative" influence and would

encourage the development of new virtues among the American people. In his 1844 essay "The Young American," which heralded the compatibility of Transcendentalism and technology, Emerson exclaimed: "Whatever events in progress shall go to disgust men with cities and infuse into them the passion for country life and country pleasures, will render a service to the whole face of this continent." Because he believed that land was physic and food for mental and physical growth, Emerson considered the farm an asylum for those who failed in urban society.²¹

Despite this almost ritualistic paeon to the new agrarianism, Emerson betrayed his ambivalence toward the pastoral idyll and the attractions of urban life in his *Journal*: "I wish to have rural strength and religion for my children, and I wish city facility and polish." For Emerson, the railroad, the master symbol of rapid urbanization, held out the possibility of the best of both worlds, providing opportunities for Americans to become acquainted with the boundless resources of the continent, and to build rural gardens and homes while maintaining frequent intercourse with the city. According to historian Michael Cowan, Emerson thus emerges as "one of the chief proponents of reconciliation" between the romantic hostility toward the urban experience and the growth of cities.²²

Edward Everett Hale likewise considered the competing claims of country and city. Admitting that "our intellectual and moral faculties are urged to the highest point of culture by the intense competition of large towns," and acknowledging the "elegant refinements, the liberal institutions, the noble charities, [and] the creative, industrious, the world-encompassing energy, of the cities," he nevertheless believed that the "contagion of vice and crime produce[d] in a crowded population a depravity of character." But despite his belief that the "want of centralization" in America produced a more virtuous people, Hale spent almost his entire adult life in Boston. His fealty to the agrarian ideal notwithstanding, Hale would not move away from the large cities that made him "tremble for the future."²³

The landscape painter Thomas Cole professed a romantic preference for the country over the city, but he too revealed an ambivalence. His 1836 "Essay on American Scenery" praised "rural nature" as an "exhaustless mine" of poetic and painterly inspiration, "an unfailing fountain of intellectual enjoyment where all may drink & be awakened to a deeper feeling of the works of genius & a deeper perception of the beauty of our existence." Cole spent the greater part of each year at his country house in Catskill, New York, and from there made frequent sketching trips to the nearby mountains as well as more extended tours "in search of the picturesque." He represented the annual prospect of returning to New York for the winter season as wearisome, professing to be happiest in the country and perceiving the city with a "presentiment something like of evil." To friend and fel-

low painter Asher B. Durand, Cole prescribed an existence similar to his own: "You must come & live in the country," he advised, as "Nature is a sovereign remedy," and "in the country we labour under more healthy influences" than in the city.²⁴

Cole's series of allegorical paintings, *The Course of Empire* (completed 1836), served as a vehicle for expressing his attitudes toward country and city. On five canvasses he portrayed the progress of civilization from a savage to a pastoral state, then to an urban one, and finally, destruction and reversion to the primitive. The pastoral state (fig. 3), embodying the balance of man and nature, was obviously the best; man and nature in their unbalanced, urban state (fig. 4) was the worst. Cole's cyclical interpretation of the progress of civilization expresses a variation of the agrarian ideology, with destruction seen as the price exacted of an urban society that dominates nature.²⁵

And yet, despite his ritualistic proclaiming of what his first biographer, Louis L. Noble, calls a "love of rural life" and a "natural aversion to the city," Cole's correspondence with Durand suggests a different reality. During the summer of 1836 he addressed more than a dozen letters to his fellow painter, pleading for the favor of a visit. Here one glimpses another side of the rural ideal, the loneliness of the country and the positive attractions of urban life and society. Although he described himself as a fine example of the "effects of country air," in encouraging Durand to forsake the city Cole admitted, "if you would pitch your tent near me I should also be benefitted." Praising country life even while longing for city news and city friends, Cole, like so many other nineteenth-century Americans, was trapped by the stereotyped definitions of country and city.²⁶

The early career of *litterateur* and social dandy Nathaniel Parker Willis offers still another illustration of the degree to which the reformulated agrarian ideology captivated nineteenth-century Americans. In the early 1840s Willis retired to a secluded glen in the Susquehanna Valley, where he hoped to spend the rest of his days. From this "altar of life-long tranquility" he wrote devastating critiques of the city and lauded the virtues of rural life. "What surprises me most in the past," he declared, "is, that I should ever have confined my free soul and body, in the very many narrow places and usages I have known in towns." In *Letters from Under a Bridge* Willis parried the questions of friends who asked how long he would be "contented in the country." "Comment, diable!" he replied, and asked instead how they could be "contented in a town." But, like Cole, Willis soon tired of his self-imposed seclusion and urged literary friends to take nearby farms on the Susquehanna, to "cluster about this—certainly one of the loveliest spots in nature." Without society the attractions of his pastoral idyll soon diminished, and Willis reported that "inevitable necessity drove him again into active metropolitan life."²⁷

From the "Editor's Easy Chair" at *Harper's New Monthly Magazine*



Figure 3. *The Course of Empire: The Arcadian or Pastoral*, by Thomas Cole, 1836.
(Courtesy, The New-York Historical Society, New York City.)

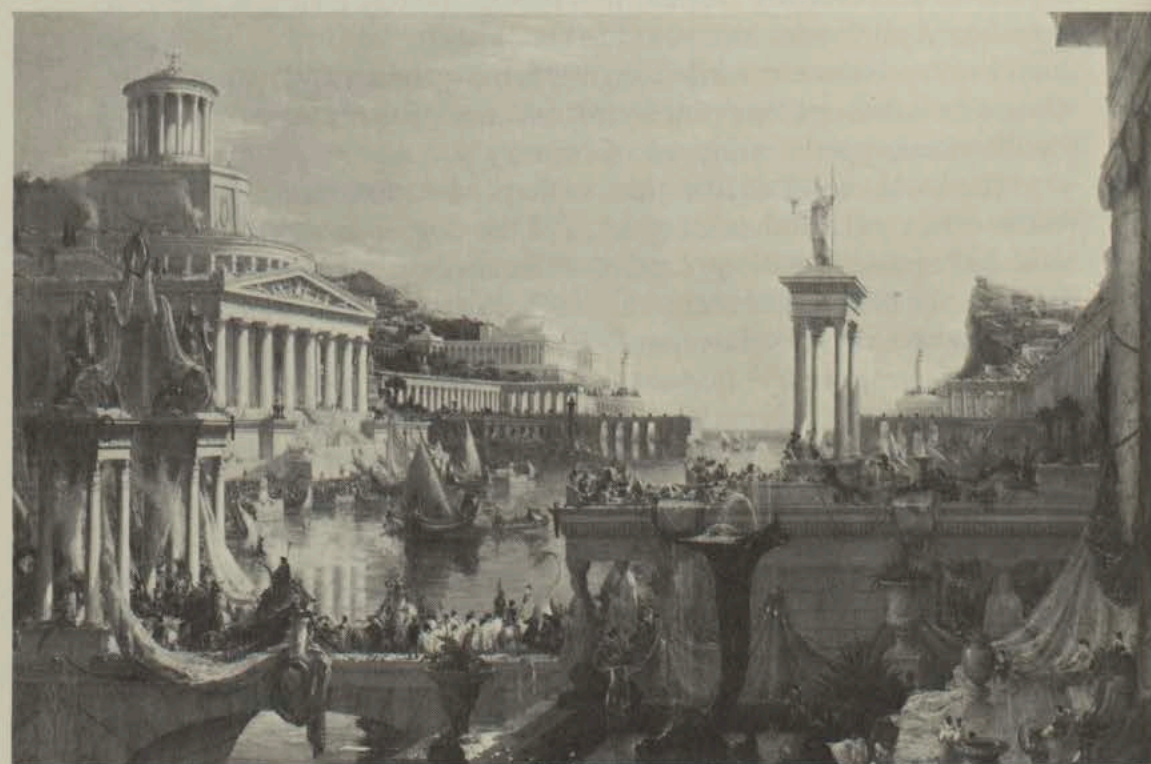


Figure 4. *The Course of Empire: The Consummation of Empire*, by Thomas Cole, 1836.
(Courtesy, The New-York Historical Society, New York City.)

George William Curtis astutely assessed the ambivalent relationship of country and city in American thought: "The poets and other people who have been so enthusiastic about the country have lived in the city," he asserted, "and wrote their eulogies within brick walls." To Curtis it was obvious that the great triumphs of civilization were achieved in cities, that a more accurate portrayal of rural life would emphasize the "silence, the seclusion, the drudging toil, the long monotony of the year, [and] the mental idleness" of the farm. The poetic descriptions of agriculture and of rural pursuits, he concluded, hardly appealed to the plowboy or the milkmaid.²⁸

Nathaniel Hawthorne also illustrated the rather somber reality of the agrarian existence. The "peril of our new way of life," he wrote of Brook Farm in *The Blithedale Romance*, "was not lest we should fail in becoming practical agriculturists, but that we should probably cease to be anything else." Rigorous labor "left us mentally sluggish in the evening," and the great minds of the associational enterprise "were fast becoming cloddish." Predictably, when the protagonist, Miles Coverdale, returned to Boston he placed city and country in a new perspective. "Whatever had been my taste for solitude and natural scenery," he exclaimed, "yet the thick, foggy, stifled elements of cities, the entangled life of so many men together, sordid as it was, and empty of the beautiful, took quite a strenuous hold upon my mind. I felt as if there could never be enough of it." What Coverdale learned at Blithedale was that the realities of agricultural labor were rather different from the rural pleasures described in pastoral idylls, and afterward he found city life much more attractive. Thus, while observing the various activities of the hotel lobby, Coverdale concluded: "All this was just as valuable, in its way, as the sighing of the breeze among the birch-trees that overshadowed Eliot's Pulpit."²⁹

Curtis and Hawthorne were correct in asserting that the awareness of the natural environment celebrated in the painting and literature of the mid-nineteenth century was an urban phenomenon, one that differed markedly from traditional agrarianism. It was an expression, in historian Perry Miller's words, of "a fundamental opposition of Nature to civilization." Taken together, however, the new attitude toward nature and the appreciation of urban cultural institutions held out the possibility of uniting the best aspects of each. After all, what was wrong with the city was that it was not "the country." As a conception, the new urban landscape sought to remedy that failing by bringing into the city large expanses of rural beauty. It was a crusade to create a new urban form, one that introduced nature as a means of countering the overcivilization of the city.³⁰

But not just any landscape would be appropriate. By mid-century the term *country* conveyed a specific set of scenic values associated with a pastoral or domesticated landscape. Unitarian minister Henry

W. Bellows explained that this celebration of nature was an urban expression of nostalgia for the country. Because of the task of subjugating the wilderness, he pointed out, backwoods farmers hated trees. City dwellers, on the other hand, trapped by the relentless gridiron and surrounded by walls of brick and brownstone, sought to preserve or create within their midst the antithesis of urban conditions, the country. Thus developed a great but understandable irony of the nineteenth century. Settlers on the frontier employed the rectangular street plan to convey at least the appearance of urban civilization, while residents of cities on the eastern seaboard attempted, through the creation of public parks and suburbs, to restore aspects of the countryside.³¹

The new urban landscape was a creative synthesis of the divergent values associated with country and city in nineteenth-century American culture. In the absence of a tradition of metropolitan leadership, this simultaneous redefinition of agrarianism and urban culture was the source of the most original developments in city form in the antebellum years. Many urban reformers felt, as Henry P. Tappan claimed, that "life in a great city is, at best, a war with nature"; their creative energies attempted to shape vicarious or actual escapes from the urban environment. To mitigate, or perhaps to camouflage and thereby make more tolerable, a necessary evil, landscape architects designed parks that would "combine the rural with the artificial in cities." Olmsted, one of the designers of New York's Central Park, believed that an urban public park should "resemble a charming bit of rural landscape, such as, unless improved by art, is never found within the limits of a large town." The park was consciously designed and created to be the country within the city.³²

For those who, like Emerson and Willis, wanted to enjoy both the pleasures of the country and the attractions of urban society, or for those who wanted a rural upbringing for their children but found it necessary to work in the city, real estate promoters developed communal spaces for homes on the urban periphery, connected to the city by railroad, steamboat, omnibus, or ferry. As early as 1823, Hezekiah Pierrepont advertised lots on Brooklyn Heights as desirable places of residence for New York's workers because the site combined "all the advantages of the country with most of the conveniences of the city." Twenty-five years later Downing could write: "Hundreds of thousands, formerly obliged to live in the crowded streets of cities, now find themselves able to enjoy a country cottage several miles distant,—the old notions of time and space being half annihilated." Thus nineteenth-century Americans attempted to resolve the competing claims of country and city by creating a new urban landscape, by bringing into or near the metropolis the physical aspects of the country. After all, George William Curtis noted, "the pleasantest life is the union of the two."³³

CHAPTER III

THE DIDACTIC LANDSCAPE: RURAL CEMETERIES

... the first really elegant public gardens or promenades formed in this country...

—ANDREW JACKSON DOWNING

The first physical expression of the evolving definition of urban form and culture in antebellum America was the development of rural cemeteries. These were usually created by nonprofit stock companies and were the first large spaces near cities laid out in the "natural" or "picturesque" style of landscape gardening that were open for public visitation. Although at first the justification for rural rather than urban cemeteries was concern for public health and the inadequacy of downtown space for burial, these cemeteries became rural retreats frequented by city residents in search of contemplative recreation, didactic landscapes whose scenery and monuments instructed visitors in morality and respect for the dead. Their popularity thus marked the confluence of two important ideas: the new attitude toward domesticated nature emerging in landscape painting, literature, and the debate over urban form; and the need for publicly constructed and maintained parks to bring country into the city.

The idea of burying the dead outside city limits had roots in antiquity, of course; the Romans had carefully separated the worlds of the living and the dead. The law of the Twelve Tables forbade interment in cities, and great heroes were buried in honored places along the Appian Way or in other suitable rural locations. But for centuries in the Western world Christians had buried their dead *ad sanctos*, in consecrated grounds adjacent to churches. Because churches were the focus of community life, most cemeteries were located in cities and towns. The medieval dead coexisted with the living, and the cemetery was a public place. In addition to its use as a facility for interment, the cemetery served as an "asylum" for meeting friends, for dancing, for gambling, and for various events. Only in the late Middle Ages did the Church forbid such profane activities, and at least until the